

You!

The only thing that makes or breaks a technology product is You—the consumer. However, you're not the silent window shopper any more, you have become the most influential force in technology, and perhaps the greatest wonder of the technology world!

Robert Sovereign Smith

In the last 5 years, the faceless masses that were confined to adopting products and spending money, have started standing up to be counted. As you have already read, we've listed Open Source as one of our technology wonders, and it's you that makes Open Source what it is.

Linux has now grown into the Free Software Foundation and Open Source. In fact, now it's not just Linux, but millions of little projects that have ended up making some of the best software there is, and it was all possible because of the Internet. As the number of people online grew, we started forming little online communities, much like the way we do in real life—the chess club, computer club, bikers club and other popular cliques you see in every college are examples.

Networking

After the wonderment of the Internet faded, it became just another tool that we used to find information and interact with other people from around the globe. The next step was obviously to start creating content and sharing information, and as a result, most of us ended up with a little space on the Net to call our own. Those of us who could afford it, ended up buying domains and hosting to set up our own Web sites, others settled for free alternatives such as Yahoo! Geocities. But how long could this continue? We are social animals after all, and before you knew it, we found ourselves gravitating to form communities.

Chat applications such as ICQ and search features enabled us to make new friends, and search for long lost buddies, or even strangers with the same interests. It was natural that most people were looking for friends of the opposite sex, because everyone, it seemed, was desperate to get a date.

In the early Internet days, there were plenty of dating services at the time anyway, and there were different communities and forums for like

minded individuals. However, if you were an IRC trivia junkie, who could code, loved motorcycles and dipping chocolate chip cookies into your strawberry milkshakes, you'd probably have to go on IRC to play trivia, then visit a forum to find the latest news from your motorcycle buddies and hope that you'd find a girl on a dating site who didn't mind sipping on a strawberry milkshake that had a few choco-chip crumbs in it...

Then came social networking sites. SixDegrees.com was probably the first, and was launched in 1997. It died soon though, and many online experts feel it was way ahead of its time. The first popular social networking site was Friendster (2002), probably because it didn't just focus on dating or any one aspect of socialising. MySpace followed in 2003, Orkut and Facebook later, and by now social networking was a rage. It's not all just fun though, and although mainly the evils of social networking make the news headlines, it has enabled many to make business contacts, outsource work and get exposure to otherwise inaccessible avenues.

Blogging

Blogging took the concept of a private diary and made it public. You could consider any online space where personal views are expressed to be a blog, and this dates back to the BBS and Usenet days. Even Yahoo! Geocities, launched many a blogger. However, this meant that people needed to design their own sites and know HTML coding. With the launch of Open Diary and Live Journal around 1998-99, people had access to easy-to-use tools to create their own blogs. Blogger then came along and joined the party, and is here to stay.

Blogging was so popular, that it prompted Google to buy Blogger in 2003. It's not just opinions anymore—photo-blogging, video-blogging, audio-blogging, micro-blogging and mobile-blogging are all ways in which to express oneself.

What blogging has done, is unearth the talents that most of us never knew we had. So if you're a network admin who loves to cook, you could have a blog dedicated to cooking, and teach the world the magic behind your *Paneer Makhanwala*—something you'd never have the chance of talking about at work with colleagues or even at home with friends. The major reason why blogging is taken seriously by everyone, is that apart from unearthing subject-matter experts that you never knew existed, it's also a very viable source of income. After Google, YouTube, Yahoo!, Wikipedia and the like, some of the most popular information resources are blogs, and millions of hits translate into quite a few dollars for bloggers who take their work seriously.

Wikipedia

Wikipedia is a completely community-driven initiative that met unquestionable success. Ever since its launch in 2001, Wikipedia has grown in popularity to

now become one of the top 10 global sites. The concept was brilliant, an encyclopaedia created and managed by a community, in a Wiki format (editable by anyone). Wikipedia gets its fair share of criticism, based on the fact that anyone can edit any page, and that popular opinion, rather than the 'right' information, always prevails. When Time magazine made You the person of the year, 2006, they cited Wikipedia as one of your greatest achievements.

YouTube

In early 2005, when everyone wanted to network or blog, YouTube was a refreshing change. There are an estimated 85 million videos on YouTube, and with all that streaming video content, it's estimated that the bandwidth cost for YouTube is Rs 4 crore a day. The best way to describe YouTube would be to call it community TV, where you can find content from almost every topic you can think of. So popular was this Internet video phenomenon that Google just had to own it. In November 2006, Google coughed up \$1.65 billion in stock to acquire YouTube. That's Rs 6,600 crore, plus the Rs 4 crore a day in bandwidth costs!

The Web

If you've noticed, we've not used the term Web 2.0 thus far. We don't like that term. If we changed that number every time something revolutionary happened online we'd probably be at Web 66.6 right now. What's remain unchanged is the fact that the Net, as always, connects us to one another. It's just the way we use it that changes, if at all. For example, we've always been able to express opinions, through the BBS, our own sites and forums. It's merely the platform that's changing, with everyone trying to bring in the numbers, offering new ways to do old things. Even YouTube is much younger than, say, those "Worlds Most Amazing Videos" shows, or those based on videos you took of your baby or pets. What's changed is that instead of you sitting in front of an idiot box, watching what's shown to you, you can now make your own videos and upload them, or just sit back and watch what you want to online, and post your opinion or a video response to something.

The evolution of the Web to "Web 2.0" can probably be attributed to the increasing popularity of the Net. With more and more of you getting online, isn't it natural for an evolution of sorts to take place? Just as the majority prefers TV to radio or newspapers, video sites seem to be leaving text and audio based sites coughing up dust. Just as we like to express our opinions when we're with friends, we're blogging and informing the world of what we feel. Call it what you want, Web 2.0 or not, the virtual world is just becoming more like you are in the real world, and everyone loves it.

